ASSEMBLY POLLS 2023

TELANGANA / BJP

FALLING OVER BACKWARDS

THE SAFFRON PARTY IS RELYING HEAVILY ON THE OBC VOTE AS A POTENTIAL GAME-CHANGER

By Amarnath K. Menon



FIGHTING FIT Union home minister Amit Shah with his cabinet colleague and BJP state chief G. Kishan Reddy (right) in Adilabad

Becoming a dependable alternative demands some complex political manoeuvring. The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) may have perfected it into a fine art elsewhere, but not when it comes to challenging two-term chief minister K. Chandrashekar Rao (KCR) and his Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS) in Telangana. Rather than calling the shots, the BJP finds itself caught in a three-way contest, with a resurgent Congress vying for power too in the coming assembly polls on November 30. The party, therefore, is going all-out in a vigorous poll campaign. "If the BJP is voted to power, the chief minister will not be confined to a farmhouse but will be among the people," says state BJP chief G. Kishan Reddy, promising free education and health cover for the poor.

To reap quick political dividends, the party is positioning itself as a champion of the OBCs (Other Backward Classes) and is pledging to appoint a CM from their midst. The strategy could well work as the OBCs make up 52 per cent of Telangana's population, and they have not had a CM from their cohort so far. The saffron party has nominated 37 candidates from the OBC community, pending an alliance with actor-turned-politician Pawan Kalyan's Jana Sena Party (JSP), which may eventually surpass the number other political parties have fielded. In addition, out of the 37 tickets that have been allocated to forward castes, 27 have gone to candidates from the Reddy community, 16 to Scheduled Castes and 10 to Scheduled Tribes. Among the 100 candidates announced so far, there are 14 women.

Courting the OBCs is a difficult proposition due to their diverse composition and non-monolithic character. "However, there is a growing consciousness among the OBC sub-castes that their voice will not be heard until they are united," contends R. Krishnaiah, Rajya Sabha MP and chairman, National Backward Classes Welfare Association. "We have been trying to bring all 140 sub-castes under one umbrella for about two decades, and have succeeded to a large extent."

While the BJP may be betting big on its promise of an OBC CM, some political analysts remain sceptical. "Raising the slogan may be relevant as a smart social engineering strategy but has no legitimacy as the BJP has not decided on a caste-based enumeration of OBCs nor has it included a quota for them in the Women's Reservation Bill," argues E. Venkatesu of the University of Hyderabad.

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The BJP, however, is also banking on the Union government's development schemes and leveraging anti-incumbency to challenge the BRS. On October 1—his first visit in the poll season—Prime Minister Narendra Modi laid foundation stones and dedicated multiple developmental projects worth Rs 13,545 crore. In all, he is addressing five rallies in the state.

But several prominent leaders such as state BJP chief Kishan Reddy, OBC Morcha chief K. Laxman, national vice-president D.K. Aruna, and BJP Madhya Pradesh in-charge Muralidhar Rao have opted out of the poll race. This is despite the BJP central election committee's decision that all senior members, whether MPs or legislators, must contest the election.

However, even as they acknowl-